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Volume Editors’ Introduction to “Discourse and Education”

A discursive approach to language and education examines educational language use in social context. Some aspects of linguistic meaning are decontextualized, encoded in grammatical categories, but most of what we communicate to each other through language is only intelligible through knowledge of and participation in heterogeneous social contexts. Potentially relevant contexts include momentary interactional configurations, individual dispositions, local practices, and enduring patterns of social organization. When we study “discourse,” we study how speakers use language to accomplish social action, presupposing and creating contextual norms, practices, and relationships as they do so.

“Education” is the process of facilitating human development through organized activities. Schooling is a historically recent, institutionalized form of education, one which has become pervasive and influential for almost all individuals and societies. Both schooling and other forms of education are mediated in significant part through discourse, because virtually all participants in educational activities communicate through language. This volume describes current research on how discursive processes of various kinds influence educational participants’ experiences, trajectories, and outcomes. If we can understand how language use mobilizes social contexts and processes as it facilitates educational communication, we can better understand and improve educational practices.

The volume has three sections. “Traditions in Discourse and Education” contains chapters on several intellectual traditions in the study of discourse that have become important to educational research – including linguistic anthropology, conversation analysis, systemic functional linguistics, critical discourse analysis, and interactional sociolinguistics. Because discourse has been such a productive concept, we could have included other traditions. But space limitations and contingent factors constrained the list. The six chapters in this first section nonetheless introduce most of the concepts crucial to understanding discourse and education. The second section, “Discourse, Power and Identities,” contains chapters that explore how widespread, macrosocial ideologies and structures influence and are constituted by language use in educational contexts. Many of these chapters attend to interactional processes and pedagogical goals as well, but they focus on how discourse facilitates and constrains social identities and power relations. The third section, “Discourse, Pedagogy and Learning,” contains chapters that emphasize pedagogical goals,

exploring how discourse facilitates and impedes learning in various contexts and subject areas. Most of these chapters also attend to power and identity, but they focus on teaching and learning. Almost every chapter mentions all three areas – traditions in discourse and education, power and identities, and pedagogy and learning. But chapters tend to focus on one or another area.

"Discourse" has been defined in various ways, and the term indexes different scholarly traditions and commitments. The contributors to this volume represent a range of perspectives, but they generally agree on four core claims about language use in educational activities. First, we must attend to language use in practice, not merely to language as a decontextualized code or to denotational messages apart from social contexts of use. Second, in order to understand language use in practice both participants and analysts attend to various local and enduring social contexts that extend beyond the speech event itself. Third, these relevant contexts are not stable but include heterogeneous resources that change over time and across social spaces. Fourth, human learning and development are constituted through complex systems of social activity and cannot be reduced to individual, interactional, or macrosocial processes in isolation. This introduction has four main parts, each elaborating one of these core claims and describing how various chapters deploy them. Every chapter presupposes more than one of the claims, so we only mention each chapter where its contribution is particularly salient.

Chapters vary in how much they focus on one or more of the four claims. The chapters also review research done in different regions of the world and different types of educational settings. We have brought together this diverse set of review chapters for two purposes. First, we intend to illustrate how various traditions have contributed to the four core claims about discourse and education. A range of scholars, from diverse intellectual, geographical, and institutional locations, have been producing related bodies of work that share key commitments. It would be useful for participants in this sometimes disparate group to be more aware of their collective accomplishment building allied approaches to discourse and education. Second, we intend to illustrate how the core claims have been applied to various educational processes and national contexts, with interestingly varied results. Those who work in these allied traditions, and others, can use the volume to learn about relevant work that might enrich their own perspectives.

Language Use in Practice

A discursive perspective draws on systematic linguistic study of language structure and meaning, as well as cognitive and psycholinguistic accounts of language meaning. But it uses these tools, along with others, to study a more complex object: the use of language to accomplish meaningful action in social context (Duranti 1997). Marx (1867/1986) and Vygotsky (1934/1987) apply the concept "unit of analysis" to social scientific problems. In their account, an adequate approach to any phenomenon must find the right unit of analysis – one that preserves the essential features of the whole. In order to study water, a scientist must not break the substance

down below the level of an individual H₂O molecule. Water is made up of nothing but hydrogen and oxygen, but studying hydrogen and oxygen separately will not illuminate the essential properties of water. Similarly, meaningful language use requires a unit of analysis that includes aspects beyond phonology, grammar, semantics, and mental representations. All of these linguistic and psychological factors play a role in linguistic communication, but natural language use also involves social action in a context that includes other actors and socially significant regularities.

The chapters in the first section of the volume review various traditions in anthropology, sociology, and linguistics that have developed this insight about the relevant unit of analysis for studying discourse. *Christie* draws on systemic functional linguistics, citing Halliday's (1978) seminal argument that language structure can only be understood if we treat language as a means for accomplishing social action – always including cognitive, relational, and textual functions. *Green and Joo* draw on interactional sociolinguistics (Gumperz 1982), an approach that combines sociolinguistics with linguistic anthropology to describe how meaningful language use depends in part on social and cultural categories from the broader context. *Kunitz and Markee* draw on ethnomethodology and conversation analysis (Garfinkel 1967; Sacks et al. 1974), traditions that have uncovered intricate social organization that speakers and hearers create as they interact with each other. *Rogers* draws on critical discourse analysis (Fairclough 2013), a tradition that combines critical social theory with close attention to how language use presupposes and reinscribes asymmetrical social relations. *Wortham and Perrino* draw on linguistic anthropology (Hymes 1974; Silverstein 1976, 2003), an approach that combines systematic semiotic analysis with attention to the social positions and ideologies inevitably mobilized in language use. These traditions differ in various ways, but they agree that any event of speaking must be understood as a complex unit that involves speakers and hearers as actors within social contexts.

Every tradition has an origin myth and an account of the predecessor that had to be overthrown. The core insight about language use in practice developed over the past half century, emerging from earlier models that treated linguistic meaning as a matter of decoding and semantic inference. According to these models – often associated with Saussurean linguistics and traditional cognitive psychology – language has one function, to communicate denotational information, and it accomplishes this function as the hearer decodes information sent by the speaker. Working against this view, Austin (1956), Jakobson (1957), Searle (1969), and others established that language in use has multiple functions, including the accomplishment of social action – and that communicating denotational information is itself a type of social action. Garfinkel (1967), Silverstein (1976), Sperber and Wilson (1986), and others established that understanding language in use requires inference. Instead of decoding a symbol that has stable meaning across contexts, participants infer from relevant context what signs mean in specific contexts of use.

This last point is often described in terms of "indexicality." Indexical signs point to potentially relevant context (Peirce 1934). Participants must first infer which potentially relevant context is in fact being presupposed by the indexicals in an

utterance and then infer from relevant context what function the utterance has (Silverstein 1992). In their chapter, *Kunitz and Markee* provide an insightful, extended account of how educational language use signals relevant context. *Valencia Giraldo* draws on Gumperz' (1982) account of contextualization cues to describe how teachers and students identify relevant contexts and make sense of classroom discourse. *Wortham and Perrino* provide a systematic overview of how educational language use becomes meaningful in practice, with the concept of indexicality central to their linguistic anthropological account.

Each of the four core claims has methodological implications, and chapters in the volume describe some of the methodological innovations and challenges that come along with recognition of that claim. For the first claim, about language use in practice, the methodological implications are clear and substantial: instead of just examining native speaker intuitions, or individual mental representations, research on educational discourse must also gather data on interactional processes as well as both local and broader social contexts. This presents obvious logistical challenges, as researchers must identify potentially relevant contexts and observe them. *Luk* describes how we cannot study language use in practice by using only external, decontextualized coding schemes. She sketches how researchers need to study dynamic, contested identities and contexts. *Reyes and Wortham* describe a new unit of analysis for studies of educational discourse: pathways of connected events, across which learning, social identification, and other social actions take shape. Instead of studying just discrete events and more enduring social patterns, they argue that one crucial type of relevant context is what Agha (2007) calls a "speech chain" – a series of events linked by a focal idea, object, or person. Adequate empirical studies of language in use must gather data from several events across relevant chains.

Local and Enduring Contexts

In order to study language use in practice, research on educational discourse must examine more than the speech event itself. It is crucial to consider the social action being accomplished in discursive events. But the meaningfulness of language use always presupposes information and activity that extends beyond the event of speaking itself (Goffman 1981). *Kunitz and Markee* discuss this issue in detail. Drawing on conversation analysis, they argue convincingly that analysts should not bring contextual information from presupposed theories into an analysis without systematic empirical evidence that the participants themselves orient to those contexts as relevant. But they also acknowledge that participants themselves always orient to some broader contexts that become crucial to the meaningfulness of language use in practice.

Over the past half century, research on educational discourse has focused on several different types of contexts that turn out to be relevant to many educational processes. The first involves macrosocial regularities, including institutions, ideologies, and identities (Bourdieu and Passeron 1977; Bowles and Gintis 1976; Foucault

1975). Educational discourse becomes meaningful against the background of macrosocial contexts, as participants presuppose and enact widely entrenched positions and categories. As mentioned above, the chapter by *Rogers* presents an overview of critical discourse analysis, a tradition that studies how macrosocial processes of various kinds manifest in and are accomplished through discourse. *Heller and McLaughlin* provide a comprehensive overview of how social reproduction is accomplished through language use, reviewing how discursive interaction in various educational contexts reinscribes hierarchical relationships.

Several other chapters review how educational discourse presupposes and helps accomplish macrosocial regularities. *Hjörne and Säljö* describe how educators sometimes use medical and psychiatric categories to label and marginalize students, especially those from certain social groups. *Sauntson* – in her useful chapter on the new research area of discourse, sexuality, and education – describes the use of homophobic language and bullying of gender nonnormative students in schools. She also reviews work on the naturalization of heterosexuality through educational discourse and the stigmatization of other sexual identities. *Mortimer* describes how national language policies can have coercive effects, shaping educational experiences for students and teachers. *Chimbutane* describes the use of indigenous languages in colonial and postcolonial African schools. The Portuguese colonial powers treated indigenous languages as threats, trying to eliminate them from schooling and encourage assimilation. But after independence the situation has not turned around. Despite some recent movement toward bilingual education, the hegemony of Portuguese continues.

In response to early work on the importance of macrosocial contexts in understanding educational discourse, many researchers began to emphasize how enduring regularities sometimes do not appear as expected (Erickson and Shultz 1982; Garfinkel 1967; Goffman 1981). Social regularities have to be produced in practice, and sometimes they are subverted or transformed in discursive interaction (Butler 1990). Various contributors to the volume review research that illustrates this important point. *Luk* describes how hybridity and subversion occur as student and teacher identities are produced in classroom discourse, such that social positioning does not always occur in predictable ways. *Hult* distinguishes between "policy-as-text" and "policy-as-discourse," insightfully analyzing how language policies are enacted in practice, often in ways unexpected by policymakers. *Lytra* shows how discursive meaning can be interactionally achieved during verbal play, in which learners accomplish both social and cognitive actions while engaged in often-overlooked types of events.

After research on discursive interaction established the importance of both macrosocial processes and the unexpected transformation of these processes in local contexts, some theorists developed approaches that included both (Erickson 2004; Giddens 1984). According to such accounts, macrosocial regularities are reinscribed and sometimes transformed in everyday interaction. Educational discourse does presuppose and tend to reproduce widely distributed ideologies, habits, and practices. But regularities must be produced continuously, and sometimes local actions or projects can change them (Levinson et al. 1996). This sort of account is

sometimes called a "macro-micro dialectic" or a "dialectic between structure and agency," and it has influenced much work on discourse and education.

In her account of sexual identities in schools, for example, *Sauntson* emphasizes not only established heterosexist ideologies and structures but also the construction of sometimes fluid and contingent identities in schools. *Heller and McLaughlin* also examine creativity and resistance against macrosocial regularities, although they describe how resistance is often subverted by domination in the end. *Christie* describes how the systemic functional linguistic approach to genre distinguishes between the "context of situation" and the "context of culture" (Martin 1985), exploring interrelations between established regularities and situational contingencies. *Hjörne and Säljö* describe how categorization of students is accomplished in practice, analyzing how the interplay of discursive activity with institutionalized practices and constraints shapes learners' experiences and outcomes. *Rogers* describes how critical discourse analysis connects critical analysis of society to the production of local discursive events. She usefully sketches different kinds of approaches, some more micro, some more macro, and some balanced.

In recent years, accounts of discourse have begun to move beyond macro and micro (Wortham 2012). Holland and Lave (2001) describe the importance of contentious practice, an arena of social activity that cannot be reduced to enduring struggles or to individual actions and identities. Lemke (2000) describes the multiple timescales at which potentially relevant processes occur, arguing that cross-timescale relations cannot be presupposed but must be explored for each individual case. Agha (2007) describes how chains of linked speech events form the basic unit of language and social relations, and he demonstrates that these chains have varied historical duration and spatial extent such that they cannot be reduced to two levels like macro-micro or structure-agency. Wortham (2012; Wortham and Rhodes 2013) argues that we must go beyond macro and micro to examine heterogeneous relevant resources from multiple scales. Different configurations of resources will be relevant to understanding different focal objects, such that there can be no general theory of resources that will always be relevant to discourse and education.

Wortham and Perrino provide a general framework for understanding discourse in educational settings, one that includes language use in discursive interaction, more widespread language ideologies, and circulation across varying scales. *Mortimer* argues that work in discourse and education must move beyond "structure" and "agency" to a more complex account. She describes how contemporary work in language policy productively examines "layered" scales and their interrelations, as well as speech chains and the recontextualization of signs across linked contexts. *Reyes and Wortham* focus specifically on pathways across linked discursive events, describing how social patterns emerge and transform as signs, individuals, habits, and ideas move across chains of events. *Hult* uses Scollon and Scollon's (2004) "nexus analysis," an approach to considering heterogeneous resources from across scales that become relevant to phenomena in discourse and education.

The need to consider both local and more enduring contexts in any adequate analysis of educational discourse has clear methodological implications. Researchers must determine which of many potentially relevant types of contexts need to be

considered. This is a complex process that cannot be addressed solely through methodological techniques. It requires both theoretical assumptions to guide analysts' attention and empirical inquiry to determine which resources play a role in the focal case. Wortham and Reyes (2015) provide a systematic approach to discourse analysis that addresses this problem. *Kunitz and Markee* provide an overview, from the more micro-level perspective of conversation analysis, of how researchers can find more enduring contexts relevant to specific cases. *Green and Joo* provide a useful historical overview of ethnographic research in discourse and education, and they provide guidelines for how to use ethnographic methods to uncover relevant scales.

Heterogeneous Resources in Motion

In order to study language use in practice, one must take into account various contexts. These contexts are not discrete, bounded sets of objects and processes. Instead, the contexts relevant to meaningful discourse include heterogeneous resources that emerge over interactional and historical time. Contemporary accounts of "culture" illustrate the trend away from theories that posit bounded, homogeneous groups. Early conceptions of culture, and dominant folk conceptions today, imagine cultures and other social groups as sets of people who share a location and have practices and beliefs in common. This emphasis on commonality and homogeneity has been challenged by contemporary accounts of globalization (Appadurai 1996), with newer work attending to the movement of people, ideas, and objects across boundaries and the mixing of heterogeneous people, ideas, and practices within previously established boundaries (Hall 2002; Lukose 2009). Today, we study culture in motion (Urban 2001).

Many chapters in the volume draw on this contemporary movement toward conceptualizing social contexts as heterogeneous and changing. *Spotti and Kroon* provide a strong argument against monoglottal ideologies and a comprehensive account of how multilingualism is the norm in times of globalization and "super-diversity." *Chimbutane* agrees that multilingualism and codeswitching are standard in Africa and much of the contemporary world, describing how most educational settings involve "translanguaging" and "polylinguaging" despite ideological attempts to erase this multiplicity. Like *Chimbutane*, *Valencia Giraldo* also explores the role of globalization and resulting heterogeneity in the global South. *Kim and Vorobel* describe how discourse communities facilitate complex, hybrid identities in the contemporary world, especially as social media create broader, more diverse networks and positions.

In addition to emphasizing the motion and hybridity of culture, contemporary accounts also describe heterogeneous repertoires and networks. The contextual resources that make meaningful discourse possible are related in complex and contingent ways, provisionally organized into networks that shift across space and time (Latour 2005). The social world cannot be analyzed as a set of stable structures with predictable relationships, because relevant resources come together into

networks that differ across times and places. Rymes (2014) describes this diversity in terms of heterogeneous "communicative repertoires." From her perspective each member of a group has somewhat different habits, ideas, and capacities, and discourse involves improvisation to align divergent tendencies even for members of the "same" group. Education then becomes the expansion of heterogeneous repertoires.

Spotti and Kroon provide a comprehensive sociolinguistic account of repertoires and apply this concept to understand educational discourse in times of super-diversity. *Nielsen and Davies* make a compelling argument that gender is more "multiple and mobile" than previously thought. They describe a complex "matrix" of structures, materialities, bodies, discourses, identities, practices, desires, and power – a heterogeneous set of resources used to produce gender differently across situations. *Luk* describes how new media are allowing social identities to become more complex and heterogeneous. *Kelly* provides an account of science itself as repertoires of discursive practices, offering a useful way to reconceptualize disciplines. *Moje* describes how schools contain many ways of knowing, believing, and valuing, drawn both from home and from school. She criticizes simple accounts of "home" and "school" discourses that assume there exist just these two separate domains. Instead, she examines how multiple discourses from various domains intersect, and she studies how educators' ideologies about discourses can influence their character. She also makes the useful point that simple "hybrids" of home and school discourses may not be educationally desirable.

The heterogeneous, emergent character of the resources that make educational discourse meaningful and effective has particular methodological implications. Researchers cannot always look in the same places for crucial data, because a context central to one process might be irrelevant to another. Instead, they must follow crucial people, signs, and objects across the pathways they travel, tracing the networks of resources relevant to a focal object. *Reyes and Wortham* describe how to do this in discourse analysis, following objects across pathways of linked events. *Nielsen and Davies* describe how more comparative and longitudinal studies are needed to analyze heterogeneous, emergent phenomena. *Kim and Vorobel* describe how new media data require an interdisciplinary, hybrid methodological approach. They explore difficulties encountered when studying distributed, heterogeneous, shifting environments, and they sketch possible solutions.

Learning Embedded in Systems

Research on discourse and education is centrally concerned with how language use reproduces and creates social groups, but work in this tradition also studies learning. Many of the contributors to this volume are deeply concerned to facilitate student learning and teacher development. For example, *Chimbutane* works to improve language teaching and bilingual education, *Hardman and Hardman* work on the pedagogical promise of dialogue, *Jackson and Nieman* work to help teachers facilitate students' deeper understandings of math, *Kelly* works to improve scientific

communication, *Spotti and Kroon* are concerned to help educators see multilingualism as an educational resource, *Valencia Giraldo* works to facilitate student learning from talk and texts, *Gardner and Yaacob* work on how pretend play can facilitate early childhood cognitive and social development, *Fisher* works as a researcher and teacher educator to facilitate second language acquisition, and *Moje* works to improve literacy in science and language arts.

Because they work on discourse, on social action in context, all the contributors to this volume see learning as something more complex than what Shweder (1991) calls "the lone thinker" – the traditional cognitivist view of humans as individual central processing mechanisms that follow universal procedures to think, even though they might operate on variable cultural contents. Some chapters in the volume move beyond this to a more complex cognitivist, Piagetian view, in which knowledge is constructed by individuals as part of action, often stimulated by interactions with others (Piaget 1954). *Fisher* gives a nuanced analysis of how learner and teacher beliefs shape their behavior. She explores the central role metaphor plays for teachers who serve immigrant students and for immigrant students' second language acquisition. *Gardner and Yaacob* review Piagetian studies on the importance of peer interaction in the individual construction of knowledge through pretend play, as well as Vygotskian studies of how more experienced others can scaffold early childhood development. *Boxer and Zhu* provide a useful overview of both psycholinguistic and sociolinguistic approaches to second language acquisition, systematically laying out the different questions addressed and approaches taken, and showing the contributions made by both traditions.

Other chapters take a largely Vygotskian approach, describing how cultural tools are deployed in educational discourse to facilitate learning. *Hardman and Hardman* apply sociocultural theory to analyze classroom discussions where teachers guide students. Using the Vygotskian concept "zone of proximal development," they explore how dialogue among teachers and students can facilitate intramental functioning and individual development through scaffolding. *Moje* draws on a contemporary extension of Vygotskian research – the concept "funds of knowledge" (Gonzalez, Moll and Amanti 2005) – describing how this concept can help educators facilitate student learning in social and cultural contexts.

The most complex and adequate contemporary account of learning comes from cultural-historical activity theory (Cole 1996; Leont'ev 1978; Engeström 1999). This approach describes how learning is embedded in and constituted through systems of resources drawn from multiple scales. *Jackson and Nieman* adopt such an approach to describe the role of discourse in mathematics learning. On their account, the teaching and learning of math is a fundamentally social phenomenon, involving multimodal ways of communicating that are embedded in social practices. *Kelly* presents science itself as composed of activity systems, and he explores the "intellectual ecology" of the classroom as a space constituted by various social practices. *Kim and Vorobel* describe the technologically mediated discourse communities made possible by social media, showing how multimodal tools deployed in these communities contribute to formal and informal learning. *Lytra* describes how

learning can be facilitated through playful talk, outside of official school discourse, with resources provided by unofficial discursive practices making essential contributions.

Methodologically, this more complex account of learning requires researchers to gather data from various contexts and activities. *Kelly* describes some of the methodological challenges created when searching for relevant information in various modalities and across diverse spaces. *Boxer and Zhu* describe the methodological difficulties confronted when documenting second language acquisition amidst the complexity of heterogeneous settings that vary along multiple dimensions. *Valencia Giraldo* argues that methodological eclecticism is needed and should be valued when studying learning in contemporary environments. Researchers must draw appropriate methodological approaches from across traditions in order to gather sufficient information on the heterogeneous systems relevant to learning.

Conclusions

It can be analytically useful to separate the four core claims made by contemporary work on discourse and education, as we have done in this introduction, but in actual language use they always interrelate. In order to study the social and cognitive functions accomplished through educational discourse we must analyze **language use in practice**, and this requires attention to **local and enduring contexts** that provide **heterogeneous resources in motion**. The fourth claim, **learning embedded in systems**, might seem separate, but it is not. Discourse in educational settings simultaneously accomplishes social processes that include ideologies, social identities, power relations, and enduring struggles, while also facilitating academic and informal learning that involves argument and evidence. These social and cognitive processes may appear to be separate and "purified" (Latour 1991). But in fact, they are woven into each other (Wortham 2006). A full account of discourse and education must engage all four claims.

The field of discourse and education has an opportunity to explore further the implications of its convergence on these four claims. Work from various traditions has converged on emergent, heterogeneous, and dynamic networks of relevant resources, as researchers work toward more adequate accounts of how educational discourse accomplishes social and cognitive functions. But we do not yet know exactly how these four claims work together or whether we are still missing important insights. Further empirical work is needed to explore whether this framework illuminates discursive action in various national contexts and institutional settings. And further conceptual work is needed to clarify how these claims interrelate. Several chapters review conceptual and empirical work that is beginning to do this.

Bakhtin (1981) claims that all sociohistorical contexts have both "centripetal" and "centrifugal" forces. Centripetal forces push for systematization and centralization. Developing one account of discourse and education, like one centered on the four claims, is centripetal. This can be a useful exercise, as these claims have substantial

empirical and theoretical backing. But Bakhtin shows us that centrifugal forces are not only omnipresent but also productive. The diversity of perspectives represented in this volume reminds us that both the world and our accounts of it change across space and time. There cannot be one best account of the human world, because that world is multifaceted and emergent. We should apply our account of heterogeneous, dynamic networks to our own field of discourse and education. Conceptual resources like the four claims can be useful in many contexts, but we must remain open to a more diverse set of resources as the field moves forward.

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